

Hanging
nepenthes
pitcher

An 18th-century engraving
of hanging nepenthes
pitcher plants

Leaf of a hanging
pitcher plant



DEATH IN THE SWAMPS
American pitcher plants catch their food in the same way as the hanging pitcher plants, but instead of hanging from leaves, their pitchers grow up from the ground. The inside of each pitcher is lined with scales of wax, so the insects are unable to hang on to the sides as they tumble toward the liquid below. Once in the liquid, the scales prevent the insects from climbing back up the sides of the pitcher.

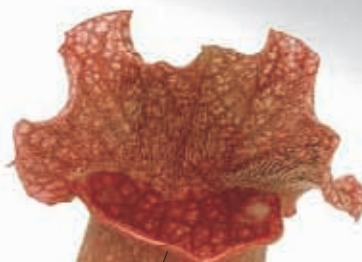
American pitcher
plant has a
frilly rim

Rim where nectar
is produced

HANGING PITCHER PLANT
The traps of hanging pitcher plants grow at the ends of their leaves. Each one is like a pitcher and has a lid to keep out the rain. Insects are lured to the pitcher by its bright color, and by sweet nectar produced around its rim. The surface of the rim is slippery, so when insects try to settle on it, they lose their footing, fall inside, and drown in the fluid at the bottom. Hanging pitcher plants grow in southeast Asia. The largest pitchers are 14 in (35 cm) deep and hold a cup of fluid.

Vertical cross-section of
a hanging pitcher

These insects are
being digested
slowly in the
fluid that collects
at the bottom of
the pitcher



COBRA LILY
The California pitcher plant, or cobra lily, looks similar to a snake rearing up and flicking out its tongue. Insects, lured by nectar, enter the plant through the mouthlike opening. Once inside the pitcher, they are confused by light shining down through small translucent areas at the top. In the attempt to escape, the insects fly continually toward the light, but eventually become exhausted, dropping into the liquid and drowning.

Patches of
translucent
cells

Entrance to
the pitcher

American
pitcher plant,
also called a
parrot pitcher
plant

Cobra lily

